

Postmortem: booking pages behind a firewall challenge

Incident date	2025-05-20 (Tuesday, afternoon JST)
Severity	SEV-2
Service	web
Incident commander	Mei
Author	Aiko
Status	Final, reviewed 2025-05-22

Summary

A firewall rule Aiko added on cloudflare at 16:02 to slow down a scraper also challenged first-time visitors on booking pages, because they arrive without a session cookie. Most of them left at the challenge page. No alert fired, since errors and latency stayed normal; support tickets and the booking-start panel showed it. Aiko switched the rule to log only at 16:58. About 2,300 booking starts were lost.

Impact

- Customers: first-time visitors to booking pages saw a challenge page between 16:02 and 16:58 JST. Returning customers with a session were not affected.
- Booking starts from new visitors fell by 62 % against the same hour the week before; about 2,300 booking starts were lost.
- Support counted 26 reports, most from businesses whose new customers could not book.
- Money and data: none affected.

Timeline (JST)

Time	What happened	Who
16:02	Aiko turns on a new cloudflare firewall rule to slow a scraper: requests to /book/* without a session cookie get a challenge page.	Aiko
16:05	First-time visitors arriving from search results start getting the challenge page instead of the booking page. Most of them leave.	cloudflare
16:21	First customer report through support: a physiotherapy clinic says new patients cannot open its booking page.	Support
16:28	After a second report, Tom, on call, checks the "Sorrel / web" board: booking starts from new visitors are 62 % below the same hour last week. No alert has fired, because errors and latency are normal.	Tom
16:34	Incident declared (SEV-2). Mei takes incident commander.	Mei
16:39	Tom checks the deploy tool. The last web deploy is 2 days old, so a rollback would not help.	Tom
16:44	Tom finds 14,950 challenges on /book/* in the cloudflare firewall events since 16:02, against about 300 on a normal afternoon.	Tom

Time	What happened	Who
16:47	Firewall rules are never changed without Aiko, so Tom pages her with the firewall events and the booking-start panel.	Tom
16:58	Aiko acknowledges, recognises her rule from 16:02, and switches it to log only.	Aiko
17:01	Challenges on /book/* fall back to normal. Booking starts from new visitors recover within ten minutes.	Tom
17:15	Mei posts on status.sorrel.app that some new visitors could not open booking pages between 16:02 and 16:58.	Mei
17:40	Aiko rewrites the rule to match only the scraper's user agent and address range, and leaves it in log-only mode for a day.	Aiko
18:30	Incident closed. About 2,300 booking starts were lost in the 56 minutes the rule was active.	Mei

What went well

- Tom ruled out a bad deploy in one look at the deploy tool and went to the firewall events next.
- Nobody changed the firewall rule but Aiko, as the handbook asks.

What went badly

- No alert fired. Errors and latency were normal, so only support tickets showed that customers were being turned away.
- The rule went straight to challenge mode, with no log-only period to show who it would catch.

Action items

Action	Owner	Due	Status
Alert when booking starts from new visitors fall more than 40 % below the same hour last week.	Aiko	2025-05-30	Open
Run every new firewall rule in log-only mode for 24 hours before it blocks or challenges anything.	Aiko	2025-05-23	Done
Add the firewall events panel to the "Sorrel / web" board.	Tom	2025-06-06	Done
Ask the scraper's operator to use the partner API instead.	Ravi	2025-06-13	Open